# The Instruction in Three Stages

Trikramopadeśa · Toh 1266 · Derge Tengyur

མན་ངག་རིམ་པ་གསུམ་པ།

The Instruction in Three Stages, known in Sanskrit as the Trikramopadeśa and in Tibetan as Men-ngak Rimpa Sumpa, is a brief practical instruction on the completion-stage yoga of the Hevajra tradition, attributed to the great Indian master Ḍombi Heruka. It leads the yogin through three successive stages, those of mantra, of wisdom, and of the secret, beginning with the kindling of the inner fire of caṇḍālī and the raising of bliss step by step through the centers of the body, and culminating in a nonconceptual meditation in which inner mind and outer objects are realized as nondual. The text also offers remedies for disturbances of the bodily winds and for imbalances of dullness and agitation that may arise in practice, and closes with the aspiration that all beings attain awakening in this very life. It is Toh 1266 in the Tengyur, where it belongs among the tantra commentaries associated with the Hevajra cycle.

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In the language of India: trikrama ubadeśa nāma. In the language of Tibet: The Instruction in Three Stages.

Homage to glorious Hevajra.

First the yogin brings together the tips of the wind channel and the sleep channel, and ignites caṇḍālī, very fiercely and for a short time. With it he burns away the concepts of the Tathāgatas and of Locanā and the other goddesses. When he has burned them in this way again and again, and when, through the igniting, whatever outer thing he focuses on and looks at seems to leap and quiver, the stage of mantra has been brought to completion.

Then he should break off that meditation. Bringing down great bliss, he holds the life wind in the center of the jewel, and, gathering the mind one-pointedly and very tightly, he directs it there again and again. When he directs it so, if he feels as though the jewel is bursting and he cannot bear it, he directs the mind again and again to the bliss at the waist of the vajra. When he directs it so, if he cannot bear the bliss, he directs the mind to the bliss at the root. When he directs it so, and again cannot bear it, he directs the mind to the bliss at the navel. When he directs it so, if again he cannot bear it, he then directs the mind one quarter-measure higher. When he directs the mind so, if again he cannot bear it, he directs the mind to the bliss within the next quarter-measure higher. When he directs it so, if again he cannot bear it, he

directs the mind to the bliss at the place one quarter-measure on. When he directs it so, if again he cannot bear the bliss, he directs the mind to the bliss at the heart.

When he directs it so, if he cannot bear the bliss and feels as though his heart is trembling and shaking, he directs the mind to the bliss at the place one quarter-measure higher. When he directs it so, if again he cannot bear the bliss, he directs the mind to the bliss at the place one quarter-measure higher still. When he directs it so, if again he cannot bear the bliss, he directs the mind to the bliss at the place one quarter-measure on. When he directs it so, if again he cannot bear it, he directs the mind to the bliss one quarter-measure higher. When he directs it so, if again he cannot bear the bliss, he directs the mind to the bliss at the throat.

When he directs it so and cannot bear the bliss, he directs the mind to the bliss at the place one quarter-measure higher. When he directs it so, if again he feels he cannot bear it, he directs the mind to the bliss at the place one quarter-measure higher. When he directs it so once more, if he feels he cannot bear it, and feels as though his voice is blocked and as though he cannot speak, he directs the mind to the bliss at the place one quarter-measure higher. When he directs it so, if again he feels he cannot bear it, he directs the mind to the bliss at the place one quarter-measure higher. When he directs it so, if again he feels he cannot bear it, he directs the mind to the bliss between the eyebrows.

When he directs it so, if he goes mad or collapses, or if whatever thing he focuses on and looks at, he feels as though he has gone mad, the stage of wisdom has been brought to completion. Breaking that off, he should take up the secret stage.

There too he restrains the breath at the nostrils. Since all phenomena are gathered into the inner mind and mental factors, he does not conceptualize outer objects, and he meditates without fixing on whatever thoughts of the inner mind arise and are felt. When he meditates in this way, his body becomes light like a tuft of cotton, and he sees directly the five signs, such as the mirage; then the secret stage has been brought to completion. Therefore he meditates without fixing on anything, the inner mind and all outer objects being inseparable and nondual. When he meditates in this way and the five superknowledges arise one after another, he attains great bliss.

If the lower body has a looseness of the bowels and feels unable to hold itself up, and there is a stabbing pain in the groin, the downward-clearing wind has been caught and has greatly swollen; to calm it, he directs the mind to the bliss between the eyebrows. When he directs it so, if the bridge of the nose aches, the bones around the eyes ache, the crown of the head aches, and the ears ache and hum, the upward-moving wind has been caught and has greatly swollen; to calm it, he directs the mind to the bliss at the navel. When he directs the mind so, if the navel stabs and feels swollen, the wind that dwells together with the fire has been caught and has swollen; to calm it, he directs the mind to the bliss at the throat. If the lips go numb and the voice feels blocked, the wind that dwells in the faculty of the tongue has been caught and has greatly swollen; to calm it, he directs the mind to the bliss at the heart. When he directs it so, if the heart feels wrung and shaken, the wind that dwells in wind has been caught and has swollen; to calm it, he directs the mind to the bliss in the center of the jewel. When he directs it so, if all the joints of the body ache and feel numb, and shivers rise over the whole body, the pervading wind has been caught and has swollen; to calm it, he meditates on the bliss as being without intrinsic nature.

When he meditates in this way, if he wants to laugh and wants to cry out aloud, it is an excessive swelling, a swelling in bliss; gathering himself very tightly once more, he meditates without fixing on the bliss. When he meditates in this way, if he becomes deeply intoxicated, without mindfulness and dull, calm abiding has become predominant; to remove that, he meditates on all inner phenomena as an illusion. When he meditates in this way, if the mind becomes excited and scattered, he meditates without fixing on the illusion. By balancing things in this way and meditating again and again, nonconceptual clarity arises, and he will attain great bliss.

When he meditates in the way described above, and the ḍākinīs come to awaken his experience, he should make the signs. If he does not know them, he should meditate without conceptual thought. When he meditates in this way, the ḍākinīs will bless him.

May all beings be endowed with the meaning of the secret mantra,
And attain awakening in this very life.

This completes The Instruction in Three Stages, composed by the great master Ḍombi Heruka.

## Translator's Notes

• The two channels whose tips are joined at the start, literally "the wind one" and "the sleep one", are not standard names; they are rendered as the wind channel and the sleep channel, and probably denote the two lateral channels. The "quarter-measure" renders "one fourth part", a unit of distance along the central channel whose exact size the text does not specify. "Groin" renders the obscure term □□□□□, and is uncertain. The winds named follow the scheme of the five winds: the downward-clearing (apāna), upward-moving (udāna), fire-accompanying (samāna), and pervading (vyāna); "the wind that dwells in wind" presumably corresponds to the life wind (prāṇa).

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## Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.